

U.S. Environmental Policy & Politics (GOV/ES 258)

Connecticut College

Instructor: Dr. Jared Heern

Fall 2026

Tuesdays & Thursdays, 9:00-10:15am

Location: Fanning Hall 315



Contact Information

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Office Hours: Tuesdays & Thursdays 10:30-11:30am (In Person), Other times by appointment

Virtual Meeting Link: <https://conncoll-edu.zoom.us/j/jheern>

Description

How should we govern our interactions with the environment? What are the best policies to respond to environmental issues? How can we balance competing interests of nature, development, business, justice, and many others? This class explores the politics and policies of the environment and the many options we have to solve environmental problems. Unit 1 will lay out the fundamentals of how we have thought about our relationship with the environment over time, and how that has broadly affected our approach to environmental policy throughout American history. It will also introduce concepts from political science and public policy to better understand the formal processes of making policy, policy design choices, important actors and stakeholders, and other forces that shape policy outcomes. Unit 2 will examine a series of environmental topics (e.g., clean air and biodiversity), define the problem, analyze various policy solutions, and the politics surrounding each of those areas. Finally, Unit 3 will focus on climate change, why addressing it is so challenging, potential policy solutions, and the obstacles for adopting those policies.

Learning Objectives

One year from taking this course, it is my goal that you will be able to:

- Outline the common causes of major environmental issues
- Identify the institutions that develop environmental policy in the U.S., explain how they make decisions, and understand how different interests influence their decisions
- Develop a policy tool belt and draw upon the tools learned in this class to propose solutions for environmental problems, while analyzing the advantages and disadvantages of different alternatives
- Explain why climate change is such a challenging problem to solve, the most promising solutions for addressing it, and the obstacles for adopting and implementing those policies
- Speak in-depth about a specific environmental problem that is important to you, the institutions important for addressing it, the various stakeholders that have an interest in the issue, and your recommended policy solutions

Required Texts

There are no required books to purchase for this course. All required reading materials will be made available through Moodle if they are not readily accessible online. **The most updated place to get readings is through Moodle.** Please contact me if you have trouble locating required course readings or additional resources for assignments.

Requirements

- **Participation**
 - Class participation comes in many forms such as assignments, coming to class, asking questions, making comments, and generally being a good citizen in the course. Many announcements and occasional assignments will be given in class only. If you miss when handouts or other items are distributed, it is your responsibility to get copies of them for yourself. I only share my lecture slides in cases of absences related to accessibility accommodations, religious observances, college-related activities, and extraordinary health issues. Otherwise, it is your responsibility to get notes from a classmate. I encourage you to use the buddy system and find someone to have this agreement with early in the semester.
- **Exams**
 - This course is comprised of three units. At the completion of Unit 2, there will be an online, in-class exam covering the lectures and reading material for Units 1 and 2. At the end of Unit 3 there will be an exam just covering the lectures and reading material for Unit 3. These exams will be open note, but not open reading material, and will be comprised of multiple choice, short answer (3-5 sentences) and long answer (6-8 sentences) questions.
- **Policy Analysis Briefs**
 - Throughout the semester you are required to write three short papers (3-4pp double-spaced, ~750-1,000 words) that analyze an environmental policy currently being proposed and discussed or recently adopted (last few years) somewhere in the U.S.. In each paper you will briefly summarize the issue and the policy (no more than one paragraph each), and then

discuss the advantages and disadvantages of that policy, ending with your overall recommendation if it should be adopted, amended, or not adopted, incorporating what we have talked about in class. Full instructions will be available on Moodle.

- **Group Policy Solutions Bee:**

- Divided into groups of 3 or 4, I will provide all groups the same list of 6-8 (semi-)hypothetical environmental issues. Your group will come up with your own policies to solve those issues and reasons why. At the end of Unit 2 we will dedicate a day of class where I'll choose some of the issues and each group will take turns presenting their solution. You will then vote on the best solutions and the group with the most points will win a prize. Before the Bee your group will submit a collective written report (one per group) that details the solutions your group is proposing to solve each problem (~500 words per solution).

- **Final Paper**

- You will select an environmental issue that is important to you. For the final paper (~1,500-2,000 words, 6-8 pages), you will outline the environmental issue, characterize the current and historical policy space, identify the key political institutions and stakeholders, and discuss the advantages and disadvantages of at least 2 current policy solutions, before ending the paper by offering your own recommend solution. Full prompt will be posted to Moodle.

Grades

Your final grade will be based on a **total of 500 available points**:

- Participation - 50 points - 10%
- Policy Analysis Briefs (x3) - 75 points - 15%
- Group Policy Solutions Bee - 50 points - 10%
- Final Paper - 100 points - 20%
- Units 1 & 2 Exam - 125 points - 25%
- Unit 3 Exam - 100 points - 20%

Extra Credit Opportunity: Environmental Documentary Review (3-4pp, details from contacting me)
- 20 points maximum

Grading Scale

Letter Grade	Percentage	Letter Grade	Percentage	Letter Grade	Percentage
A	93-100%	A-	90-92%	B+	87-89%
B	83-86%	B-	80-82%	C+	77-79%
C	73-76%	C-	70-72%	D+	67-69%
D	63-66%	F	0-59%		

Missed Tests & Late Assignments

Assignments will be docked 5% of total points every 12 hours they are late, beginning from the deadline. Consideration will be given for extensions **only** if students make arrangements with me before a due date, with exceptions made on limited a case-by-case basis for exceptional circumstances. I try to be flexible with deadlines, but you must communicate any circumstances that will prevent you from completing a requirement on time as soon as possible.

Attendance Policy

Attending class is crucial for your own success, as well as contributing to the learning of your classmates. **You are allowed to miss two class periods without any excuse** or information provided to me. Additional absences will require pre-clearance or documentation explaining the absence. After two unexcused absences, additional unexcused absences will result in 10 points being deducted from your participation grade. Three additional unexcused absences (for a total of 5), will result in failure of the course. I understand that this class only comprises one component of your very busy and sometimes unpredictable lives, and I try to be flexible and accommodating. However, you need to be able to communicate when unable to attend class so that we can work together to ensure you still meet the requirements and objectives of the course. Refer back to the participation requirement about information and materials missed in class.

Classroom Technology Policy

Complementary to the attendance policy and graded participation, part of being a good citizen of the class is being present, not distracted, and not distracting to your classmates. To help avoid these distractions, **laptops and tablets are not allowed to be used during lectures** (with the exception of accessibility accommodations). There may be times during discussions and other activities where these devices will be useful and necessary, but please refrain from using them unless otherwise specified. Writing notes by hand is a valuable skill to develop, increases information retention, and these handwritten notes can be used on quizzes and exams.

Office Hours

Please come see me! Office hours provide students with additional opportunities to review or ask questions about the class discussions and assignments. Connecticut College faculty encourage students to go to office hours so they might learn about your interests, both inside and outside the classroom. In addition to talking about class material and assignments, you may find you share common interests, such as music, books, hobbies, and movies. If a professor knows your interest, they may inform you about campus programs and activities or other opportunities like fellowships and scholarships. Most importantly, a professor who knows their students writes better letters of recommendation. Successful students at Connecticut College make time to go to their professors' office hours. All Connecticut College faculty are required to have office hours on their syllabus and posted on their office door. If you cannot make your professor's scheduled office hours, contact your professor to set up an appointment.

Credit Hour Definition

A semester course is normally equivalent to four credit hours. Connecticut College complies with federal regulations defining the credit hour. For each credit hour awarded, a course will provide an average of at least one hour of classroom or direct faculty instruction (class meetings, labs, review sessions, field trips, office hours, film screenings, tutorials, training, rehearsals, etc.) and at least two hours of out-of-class work (homework, preparatory work, practice, rehearsals, etc.) per week.

The Connecticut College Honor Code

Academic integrity is of the utmost importance in maintaining the high standards of scholarship in our community. Academic dishonesty is considered to be a serious offense against the community and represents a significant breach of trust between the professor, the classmates, and the student. There are many forms of academic dishonesty including plagiarism, falsifying data, misrepresenting class attendance, submitting the same work in two courses without prior approval, unauthorized discussion or distribution of exams or assignments, and offering or receiving unauthorized aid on exams or graded assignments. Students violating the Honor Code may be referred to the college's Honor Council for resolution. In this class, at a minimum, exams and assignments that are determined to violate the honor code will result in a failing grade.

AI Policy

Generative AI programs like ChatGPT are rapidly becoming powerful tools to enhance many tasks, academic and otherwise. However, turning in work composed by AI tools as your own is unacceptable and will be considered plagiarism. Appropriate uses of these tools might include summarizing and organizing sources, suggesting outlines for a writing assignment, and proofreading and asking for feedback on **original written** work. However, it is important to note that the output of these tools is not the same as search engines and can be flawed in numerous ways (e.g., fictitious citations, bias, misunderstanding of a prompt). You should always critically evaluate AI responses, compare them to non-AI sources of information and what you already know, and **always turn in work that is originally written by you and, at most, informed and assisted by AI** (if you choose to use it at all). Violations of this policy will be considered a violation of the Honor Code and, at a minimum, will result in a failing grade for the assignment. Because this is an environmentally focused class, it is also worth noting the significant environmental impacts, such as energy and water consumption, from AI technology, and environmental justice concerns related to the communities that are disproportionately bearing these impacts.

Title IX Statement

As a faculty member, I am deeply invested in the well-being of each student I teach. I am here to assist you with your work in this course. If you come to me with other non-course-related concerns, I will do my best to help. It is important for you to know that all faculty members are trained and required to report any incidents of gender-based discrimination, including discrimination based on gender identity, gender expression, and sexual orientation. This means that I cannot keep information confidential about sex-based harassment, sexual assault, dating violence, domestic

violence, stalking, or other forms of gender-based discrimination, and that I will report that information to the Title IX office, if it is shared with me. However, the Title IX office in response to notice from me will reach out to you to offer support and resources, and offer you the opportunity to file a formal Title IX complaint, which is up to you. Nicole Powell, the Director of Sexual Violence Prevention and Advocacy, can advise you confidentially as can Counseling Services and any of the College chaplains or Confidential Advocates. Nicole can also help you access other resources on campus and in the local community. You can reach Nicole at spowell2@conncoll.edu, or make an appointment with Nicole or one of the other Confidential Advocates at <http://bit.ly/ConnCollSVPA>.

The College sex-based harassment, dating violence, domestic violence, stalking, and nondiscrimination policies are in the Equal Opportunity, Harassment and Nondiscrimination Policy, which can be found [here on the College's website](#). There you will find the policies, definitions, procedures, and resources. If you need to report an incident or have any questions about the policy, you can contact the Title IX Coordinator, Megan D. Monahan, J.D., at 860-439-2624 or mmonahan@conncoll.edu.

Academic Resource Center

The Academic Resource Center (ARC) offers services to support your academic work such as study skills workshops, time management, coaching and tutoring. Its offices are located on the second floor of Shain Library. Students can make appointments by clicking on this link: <https://forms.gle/BQecmVdK8Bg1sv5P7>. The ARC is open to the community as a quiet study space at any time the library is open. Professional staff is there for appointments Monday – Friday, 8:30 – 5:00 (evenings are by appointment only). If faculty or students have any questions or concerns, they should contact Patricia Dallas (pdallas@conncoll.edu).

Writing Center

The Roth Writing Center provides one-to-one peer tutoring (free of charge) to help student writers of all abilities during all stages of the writing process. If you're a confident, experienced writer, our tutors can help you to push your ideas and polish your style; if you're a relatively inexperienced and not-so-confident writer, they can help you to work on grammar or organization or whatever you need. Working with a tutor gives you the opportunity to share your work-in-progress with an actual reader so that you can get useful feedback on that work *before* you have to turn it in for a final grade. You can make an appointment by using the Google Calendar link on the Writing Center's website at <http://write.conncoll.edu/> or by emailing the Writing Center at writingcenter@conncoll.edu; a new calendar of appointments will become available by the second week of each semester.

Office of Student Accessibility Services

Connecticut College complies with Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act of 1973 and the Americans with Disabilities Act. If you have a documented disability and have been approved for academic accommodations, please have your Faculty Notification Letter emailed to me through the Student Accessibility online management system (AIM) and schedule a meeting during my office

hours as early as possible in the semester so that we can discuss the logistics of your accommodations. **It is crucial you do this so that we can facilitate your best experience in the class while ensuring you satisfactorily meet the course requirements.** If you are not approved for accommodations, but have a disability requiring academic accommodations, or have questions about applying for accommodations, please contact Student Accessibility Services at 860-439-5428 or sas@conncoll.edu.

Classroom Recording

With the exception of those granted accommodations through the Office of Student Accessibility Services, students are prohibited from audio, video, or photographic recording during class periods or out-of-class meetings with the instructor without explicit permission from the instructor. Recordings approved in this manner may not be shared in any form without permission of the instructor. Violations of this policy shall be considered an Honor Code violation.

Respecting Personal Pronouns and Identity

Everyone deserves to be referred to and addressed in accordance with their personal identity. As a faculty member, I am committed to ensuring my classroom affirms people of all gender expressions and gender identities. In this course, we will only use the name and pronouns of each individual's choosing. The repeated usage of incorrect names and/or pronouns are against Connecticut College policy and may constitute a Title IX policy violation as well as a violation of state and federal law. If you have any specific questions on Title IX policy email our Title IX Coordinator, Megan Monahan at mmonahan@conncoll.edu.

In the classroom, be assured that you will always be referred to by the name and pronouns you choose. If you go by a different name than your legal name, Connecticut College has a process to change your preferred name on most campus systems. If you want to learn more about this process go to conncoll.edu/equity-inclusion/preferred-name-faq/ or email GSP@conncoll.edu.

Students, faculty and staff are now able to choose and share their pronouns within the college community by using the Preferred Name/Pronouns link on the Account navigation menu in CamelWeb and the CC Mobile App. Your gender pronouns will appear in the internal directory located in CamelWeb and the CC Mobile App. If none are selected, or if "Not Applicable" is selected, no pronouns will display. Enrolled students' gender pronouns will also display in Moodle for instructors via the class participants page.

Pronouns are one way to affirm someone's gender identity, but they are not necessarily indicative of a person's gender identity. Commonly, they/them is a gender-inclusive pronoun used by a variety of identities. However, while some people use they/them, others may use pronouns like ze/zem, xi/xim, he/him, she/her, any combination of those and/or many others. They may even reject pronouns altogether and use their name in place of pronouns. Remember to ask for pronouns, listen, and then respect the gender identities of those around you by using the proper terminology. If you have any further questions or you want to learn more about gender & sexuality, please do not hesitate to contact the Director of Gender & Sexuality Programs at gsp@conncoll.edu.

Schedule (Subject (and likely) to change with notification)

Unit 1: Fundamentals of Environmental Governance

Week 1

Wed (9/1): Course Introduction

Topics:

- Overview of course, objectives, and expectations
- Introductions
- Syllabus

Reading:

- None

Thurs (9/3): Thinking About Environmental Issues

Topics:

- Defining environmental issues and their complexity
- Anthropocentrism, Biocentrism, Ecocentrism
- Class Discussion: Tragedy of the Commons

Reading:

- Hardin, Garret. 1968. "The Tragedy of the Commons."
- Bell, Michael. "Organizing the Ecological Society." in *Invitation to Environmental Sociology*. (On Moodle)

Week 2

Tues (9/8): American Environmental History I

- First Settlers to the Transcendentalists
- John Muir & Gifford Pinchot

Readings:

- Vaughn. "A Historical Framework for Environmental Protection" in *Environmental Politics*. (On Moodle)
- Pinchot, Gifford. 1909. "The ABCs of Conservation."

Thurs (9/10): American Environmental History II

Topics:

- Carson and Environmental Protection
- Discussion: Conservation vs. Preservation in National Parks

Reading:

- NRDC. 2015. "The Story of Silent Spring".
- Abbey, Edward. 1968. "Polemic: Industrial Tourism and the National Parks." From *Desert Solitaire*.

Week 3

Tues (9/15): American Policy Process I

Topics:

- The Legislative & Regulatory Process

- Federalism and the States
- Polarization, Gridlock, and their Consequences

Reading:

- Watch CrashCourse, How a Bill Becomes a Law
- Watch CrashCourse, Federalism
- Bergquist, Parrish and Christopher Warshaw. 2019. "Elections and Parties in Environmental Politics." in *Handbook on U.S. Environmental Policy*. ed. David Konisky.

Thurs (9/17): American Policy Process II

Topics:

- Policy Models & Typologies
- Discussion: Who wins and who loses?
- Policy Feedback

Reading:

- Smith, Kevin B. & Christopher W. Larimer. 2017. "Does Politics Cause Policy? Does Policy Cause Politics?" *The Public Policy Theory Primer*. Chapter 2. (On Moodle)

Week 4

Tues (9/22): Environmental Policy Tools I

Topics:

- Command and Control/Market-based/Voluntary Programs
- Advantages and disadvantages of different tools

Reading:

- Review Linquiti Policy Chart On Moodle
- Paddock, 2012. "Beyond Deterrence: Compliance & Enforcement in the Context of Sustainable Development." 42 *Envtl. L. Rep. News & Analysis* 10622

Thurs (9/24): Environmental Policy Tools II

Topics:

- Continuation from Tuesday
- Discussion: Local enviro policy issues and their potential solutions

Reading:

- **Find a news article with a local environmental issue (i.e. Conn/New London/New England) to share with the class that you want to work on**

Week 5

Tues (9/29): Environmental Policy Influences

Topics:

- Environmental economics and externalities
- Benefit/Cost Analysis
- Public Opinion

Reading:

- Polasky & Binder. 2012. "Valuing the Environment for Decisionmaking," Issues in Science & Technology.

- NPR. 2020. "How Government Agencies Determine The Dollar Value Of Human Life." *All Things Considered* Interview.
- Mildenberger & Leiserowitz. 2017. "Public opinion on climate change: Is there an economy–environment tradeoff?" *Environmental Politics* 26(5):801-824.

Thurs (10/1): Environmental Justice

Topics:

- History of the EJ Movement
- Causes & Consequences of environmental injustice
- Discussion: Group Examples of EJ Issues

Reading:

- Mohai, Pellow, and Roberts. 2009. "Environmental Justice." *Annual Review of Environment and Resources* 34: 405-430.
- **Group Assigned News Article - See Moodle for Assignment**

****FIRST ANALYSIS BRIEF DUE by 11:59pm Sunday, October 4th****

UNIT 2: Environmental Problems and Their Solutions(?)

Week 6

Tues (10/6): Waste and Toxics I

Topics:

- The Solid Waste System
- Discussion: Extended Producer Responsibility Laws

Reading:

- Etim et al. 2026. "Policy instruments and cultural currents shaping recycling behaviours: A systematic review." *Environmental Development* 101432
- Alderman, Nancy. 2023. "OP-ED | Why Is Passing An Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) Law So Important?" CT News Junkie.
- Pierce, Lisa McTigue. 2024. "OP-ED | Why I'm Against a Packaging Tax." Packaging Digest.

Thurs (10/8): Waste and Toxics II

- Hazardous Waste & Toxics
- RCRA & CERCLA
- Nuclear and Military Waste

Reading:

- "Love Canal: Timeline and Photos." 2026. University of Buffalo.
- Gartland, Kevin. 2022. "Superfund: An Assessment of the Comprehensive Environmental Response, Compensation, and Liability Act (CERCLA)." Yale Center for Environmental Policy & Law.

Week 7

Tues (10/13): Clean Air

Topics:

- History & Sources of Air Pollution in U.S.
- Clean Air Act & its Amendments

Reading:

- EPA. "Evolution of the Clean Air Act"
- Holladay, J. Scott. 2011. "Valuing the Clean Air Act: How Do We Know How Much Clean Air is Worth?" *Institute for Policy Integrity*

Thurs (10/15): Clean Water

Topics:

- Dams & Bureau of Reclamation
- Clean Water Act & Safe Drinking Water Act
- Class Discussion: Water Justice & Flint

Reading:

- Lewis, Andrew S. 2022. "The Clean Water Act at 50: Big Successes, More to Be Done." *YaleEnvironment360*
- Bennett, Nick. 2022. "Shortcomings of the Clean Water Act." *Maine Policy Review* 32(1)
- Denchak, Melissa. 2024. "Flint Water Crisis: Everything You Need to Know." NRDC

****SECOND ANALYSIS BRIEF DUE by 11:59pm Sunday, October 18th****

Week 8

——Fall Break - No Class Tuesday, 10/20——

Thurs (10/22): Land Use and Biodiversity

Topics:

- Class Discussion: Federal Land Management Agencies & Their Missions
- FWS & Endangered Species Act

Reading:

- Watch National Park Diaries. "Here's Who Manages YOUR Public Lands" and be prepared to discuss
- Carolan, Michael. 2008. "The politics in environmental science: The Endangered Species Act and the Preble's mouse controversy." *Environmental Politics* 17(3): 449-465.

****GROUP POLICY BEE REPORTS DUE by 11:59pm Sunday, October 25th****

Week 9Tues (10/27):

- **GROUP POLICY SOLUTIONS BEE** (No New Reading)
- Units 1 & 2 Review

Thurs (10/29):****Units 1 & 2 Exam******UNIT 3: Energy & Climate Change****Week 10**Tues (11/3): History of Climate Policy in the U.S.

Topics:

- Early developments & almost solutions (1960s-1980s)
- Politicization (1990s)
- Waxman-Markey and CPP in 2010s

Reading:

- Mildenberger, Matto. 2021. “The development of climate institutions in the United States”. *Environmental Politics* 30(51): 571–592
- **Optional Skim**: Rich, Nathaniel. 2018. “Losing Earth: The decade we almost stopped climate change. A tragedy in two acts.” *New York Times Magazine* 5 August.
- Naomi Klein response to Rich. “Capitalism Killed Our Climate Momentum, Not ‘Human Nature’”. *The Intercept*. August 3, 2018.

——All-College Symposium - No Class Thursday, 11/5——**Week 11**Tues (11/10): The U.S. Energy System I

Topics:

- Sources of GHGs in the U.S.
- Basics of the energy system: Generation, Transmission, Distribution

Reading:

- Primer on U.S. Energy System
- Watch “Last Week Tonight: The Power Grid”

Thurs (11/12): The U.S. Energy System II

Topics:

- Politics of the energy system
- Electric Utilities & Public Utility Commissions

Reading:

- Watch -“Last Week Tonight: Utilities”
- Roth. 2023. “The revolving door at public utilities commissions? It’s alive and well.” LA Times Boiling Point. June 8th.

****FINAL ANALYSIS BRIEF DUE at 11:59pm Sunday, November 15th****

Week 12

Tues (11/17): Climate Policy Tools I

Topics:

- Command and Control
- Market Based

Reading:

- Parrish Bergquist et al. 2020. "Energy policy and public opinion: patterns, trends and future directions." *Progress in Energy*

Thurs (11/19): Climate Policy Tools II

Topics:

- Finish Market Based
- Voluntary/Inflation Reduction Act
- Discussion: Survey of State Policy Portfolios

Reading:

- Bergquist and Warshaw. 2023. "How climate policy commitments influence energy systems and the economies of US states." *Nature Communication*
- Review Rocky Mountain Institute's State Climate Action Scorecards and Dashboard. Pick a state (home state, favorite state, whatever) and make observations about their portfolio

——Gobble, Gobble - No Class 11/24 & 11/26——

Week 13

Tues (12/1): Climate Advocacy & Obstruction

Topics:

- Effective Advocacy Tactics
- Climate Change Countermovement (CCCM)

Reading:

- Dunlap, R.E. and A.M. McCright. 2015. "Challenging climate change: The denial countermovement." Chapter 10 in *Climate Change and Society: Sociological Perspectives*. R.E. Dunlap and R. J. Brulle, editors. Oxford. (On Moodle)
- CSSN Briefing, Robert Brulle-- The Structure of Obstruction.
- Basseches, J.A., et al. 2022. "Climate policy conflict in the US states: a critical review and way forward". *Climatic Change*, 170(3), pp.1-24.

Thurs (12/3): Climate Justice

Topics:

- Finish Advocacy and Obstruction
- Climate vulnerability and just transition opportunities

Reading:

- Carley, Sanya and David Konisky. 2020. “[The justice and equity implications of the clean energy transition.](#)” *Nature Energy* 5(August): 569-577.

Week 14

Tues (12/8): International Climate Solutions

Topics:

- International Climate Institutions
- Paris Climate Agreement and Drawbacks

Reading:

- Ciplet, D. and Roberts, J.T., 2017. “Climate change and the transition to neoliberal environmental governance.” *Global Environmental Change*, 46, pp.148-156.

Thurs (12/10):

****Unit 3 Exam****

****FINAL PAPER DUE by 12:00pm on Tuesday, December 22nd****

Last Updated August 25, 2026